

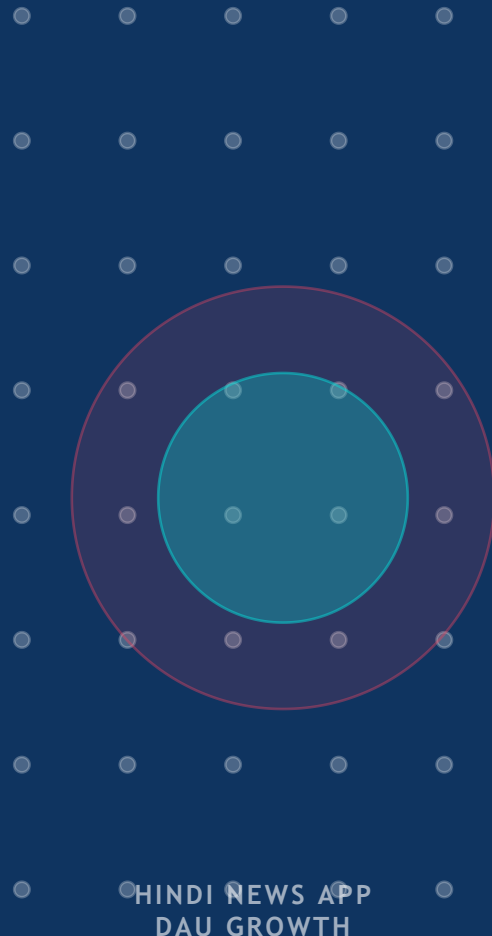
PRODUCT MANAGEMENT · CASE STUDY

Why Is Our DAU Not Growing?

A data-driven diagnosis of stagnant daily active users in a Hindi digital news app and three product features designed to fix it.

Focus: Growth & Engagement

App: Hypothetical Hindi News Platform · Scale: 14M+ Installs



HINDI NEWS APP
DAU GROWTH

The Problem & My Approach

The Problem

A large-scale Hindi news app with 14M+ installs was seeing flat DAU. Despite strong brand equity in core Hindi-speaking states, the numbers weren't moving.

The question I asked:

"Is this a new user problem, an existing user problem, or an acquisition problem, or all three?"

Spoiler: it was all three. Each required a distinct diagnosis and a distinct solution.

My Approach

01

Benchmark the data

Compare app metrics against industry standards to identify where performance gaps exist.

02

Size the opportunity

Build a TAM funnel to understand total addressable users and current penetration.

03

Diagnose root causes

Break flat DAU into three distinct sub-problems, each with different drivers.

04

Design targeted solutions

Propose one feature per problem, with clear rationale and projected impact.

Starting With What the Numbers Say



14.3M

Avg. App Install Base

Nationwide



5.45M

Daily Active Users

38% of installs



10.24

Avg. Min / User /
Day

Per session



38%

D1 Retention

New users only



24%

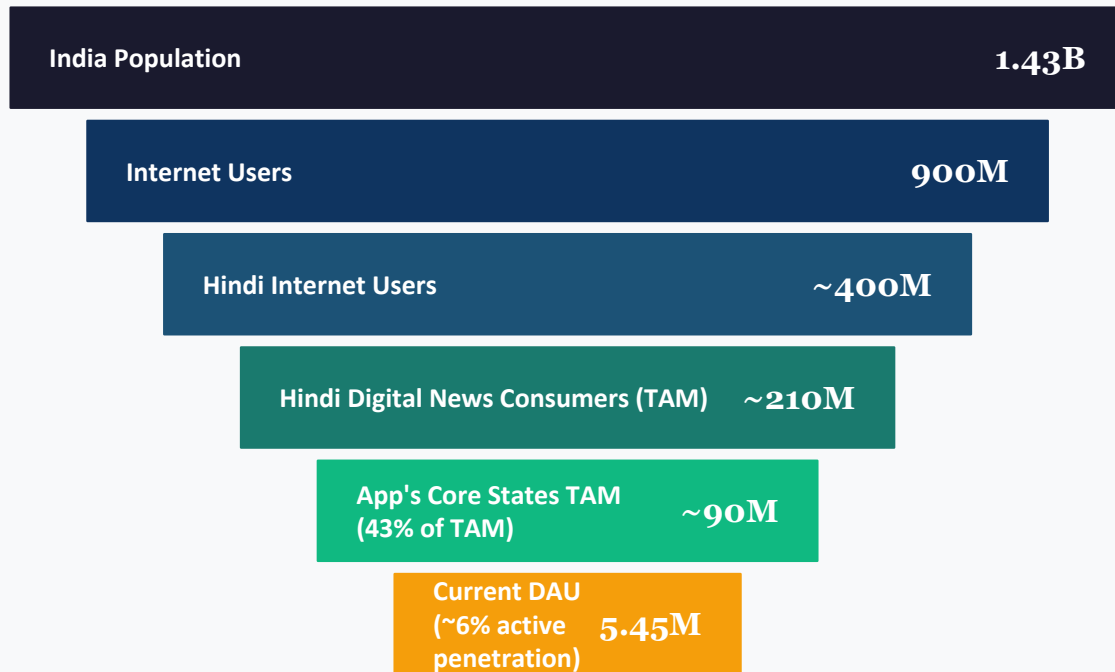
D7 Retention

New users only

Key Observation

- D7 retention at 24% is 11–16 points below the industry best-in-class benchmark of 35–40% - a critical signal of weak habit formation.
- Only 5.45M of 14.3M installs are daily active - meaning 62% of users who downloaded the app are not engaging daily.
- Flat DAU despite a large install base suggests a retention + reactivation problem, not purely an acquisition problem.

How Big Is the Real Opportunity?



~6% Active Penetration

At 5.45M DAU vs 90M core TAM, the app reaches only 6 out of every 100 addressable users daily.

~8M DAU Gap

Reaching just 15% active penetration — a realistic medium-term target — would add ~8M DAU without expanding beyond the existing stronghold.

No Need to Chase New Markets

The core states TAM alone provides more than enough headroom. The priority is depth, not breadth.

Three Problems, One Flat Number

ROOT CAUSE ANALYSIS

Treating flat DAU as a single problem leads to generic solutions. Breaking it apart reveals three separate issues — each needing its own fix.

01

New User Drop-Off

24%

D7 Retention

Best-in-class: 35–40%

New users aren't forming a daily habit. The gap of 11–16 points vs. benchmarks points to weak onboarding and no compelling reason to return within the critical first 7 days.

02

Dormant Install Base

9M

Inactive installs

62% of install base not active

9 million users downloaded the app but aren't opening it daily. This is an engagement and reactivation problem, these users know the brand but aren't forming a habit.

03

Penetration Gap

6%

Active penetration

15% target = +8M DAU

Even within the app's core market, only 6% of the addressable audience is a daily active user. Organic acquisition and shareability mechanics are underdeveloped.

SOLUTIONS

One Feature Per Problem

Each solution is mapped to exactly one root cause — no feature tries to solve everything at once.

Problem	Feature	Mechanism	Primary Metric
New User Drop-Off	What You Missed	Personalised digest of top 5 missed stories sent after 3+ days inactivity - creates FOMO and re-entry	D7 Retention ↑
Dormant Install Base	Rapid 100 News	Daily swipeable briefing with voice anchor migrates the morning news habit from TV to mobile	DAU ↑ + Session Length ↑
Penetration Gap	On This Day	Nostalgia card (top story, 1 year ago) drives organic sharing. Every share is a potential new user acquisition	Organic Acquisition ↑

Each feature was also assessed for competitive whitespace — none of the three exist in direct competitors in the Hindi news app category.

Rapid 100 News

Solves: Dormant Install Base · Target: Existing & Lapsed Users

What it is

A daily briefing of the top news stories in a rapid, swipeable card format. Each card is a manually or automatically produced swipeable story with a DB anchor or AI voice-over designed to be consumed in one session, mimicking the 'Rapid 100' format popular on news TV.

Why it works

- This is habit migration, not habit creation - the morning news behaviour already exists on TV.
- Audio layer solves low-literacy friction and enables passive consumption during commute/cooking.
- Streak mechanics and share cards create a daily return loop and a built-in acquisition engine.

Anchor Voice

Real voice, not TTS.
Trust from TV transferred to mobile.

Streak Badge

Habit loop - missing a day has a visible cost.

Share Card

One-tap WhatsApp share ensures acquisition built into the product.

Skip & Expand

Tap to read full story; briefing resumes where you left off.

Competitive Gap

Inshorts offers short cards but no voice layer or streak mechanics. No Hindi news app has this format.

~7L

DAU increase
(10% of 9M dormant)

+2min

Avg. session length
(20% of current DAU)

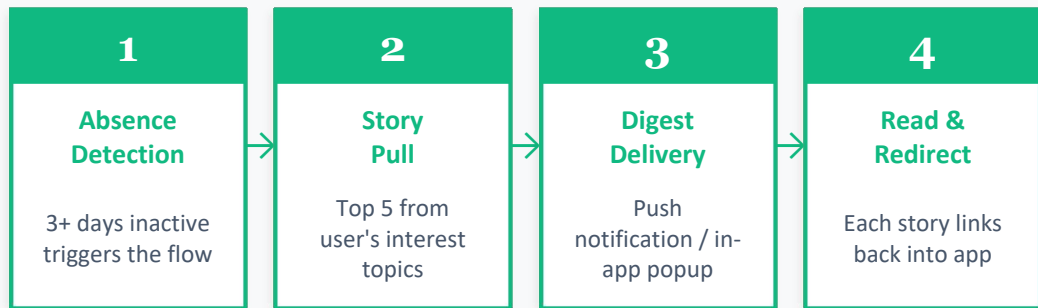
What You Missed Digest

Solves: New User Drop-Off · Target: Users Inactive for 3+ Days

What it is

When a user has not opened the app for 3+ consecutive days, they receive a personalised digest of the top 5 stories from their interest topics since their last session -not generic breaking news, but specifically what they missed.

How It Works



- Generic re-engagement pushes are ignored, a personalised topic digest creates real FOMO around specific stories the user cares about.
- Gives a summarised view of missed days, reinforcing the habit of returning to the app.

14%

D1→D7
drop-off today

+5–6%

D7 retention
uplift projected

Competitive Gap

Google News has a 'For You' feed but no gap digest. DailyHunt sends generic pushes. InShorts has no re-engagement mechanic at all.

On This Day

Solves: Penetration Gap · Target: All Users

What it is

A daily card in the main feed showing the top story from exactly one year ago - a nostalgic throwback with a concise summary and an update on how it evolved or was resolved.

Best content categories

 Politics

 Crime & Courts

 Sports

 Entertainment

 Policy

 Army & Defence

 National Pride

 Terror & Security

Key insight: Best stories = big enough to remember + open-ended enough to have a 'what happened next'. No competitor in the Hindi news app space currently runs this format.

5M
DAU

Starting base



20%

Engage with card



5%

Share the story



7,000+

Daily new users
(30% non-users → 40% convert)

What This Exercise Demonstrates

~7L

DAU increase

Rapid 100 News

+5-6%

D7 Retention

What You Missed Digest

7,000+

Daily new users

On This Day (organic)

Key PM Learnings From This Analysis

Disaggregate the metric

Flat DAU is not one problem. Breaking it into retention, reactivation, and acquisition reveals distinct causes and prevents generic fixes.

Size before you solve

The TAM funnel showed that the biggest opportunity was depth within existing markets (6% → 15% penetration), not chasing new geographies.

Compete on behaviour, not features

Each feature was designed to migrate an existing user behaviour (TV news, memory nostalgia) rather than create a new one, lowering adoption friction significantly.

Build acquisition into the product

The share card in Rapid 100 and the shareable nostalgia card in On This Day turn every engaged user into a distribution channel -zero incremental media spend.